Research Course — Planning Meeting Notes

"Claude Code / AI tools for researchers" — course design session

ATTENDEES	FORMAT	SOURCE MATERIAL
Bas · Marc · Gjorgji · Joaquim · Marleen	In-person planning meeting	Audio recording, transcript, mind map

1. Purpose & Context

The group is designing a new short course that teaches researchers and colleagues (not yet students) to use agentic AI coding tools — primarily Claude Code, alongside GitHub — for research workflows. The course runs as three evening lab sessions plus one introductory session. The stated top-level learning objective is **awareness**: participants should understand what these tools can do, where their weak points are, and how to use them responsibly, rather than being pushed toward maximal AI usage.

2. Key Decisions

Structure: One intro session + four labs, run across three evenings (Day 1 covers the intro plus two labs; Days 2 and 3 cover the rest — see the finalized breakdown in §3). Each evening runs roughly 18:15–21:00, with the room booked from 17:30 and available until 22:00. Sandwiches served early (17:30–18:30) so people don't get sleepy mid-session; no pizza.

Schedule: Wednesday evenings are the preferred slot. Avoid 9–15 November — Gjorgji is at the ACM Multimedia conference and Marc is also away that week. Sessions should land either one before and two after that window, or entirely after it.

Tooling & access: Set up a GitHub organization/team for the course so participants are invited directly (avoids the friction of manual account creation). Prepare a PowerShell setup script for Windows users to install prerequisites; Mac/GitHub Desktop is considered easy enough already.

Subscriptions: Give every participant a Claude Pro subscription (~€100 value) for **three months**, not one — one month covers the course itself, but the group wants to encourage continued experimentation afterward. Budget was described as generous and mostly already approved.

API credits: A small API budget (order of €20/participant) may be needed for the library-tool exercise, which calls external literature APIs (OpenAlex, Semantic Scholar, Scopus). Anthropic has locked down using a Claude subscription's terminal session as a backdoor API, so a genuine small API allowance is required for that exercise.

Scope boundary: The course stays focused on agentic tools (Claude Code) and will *not* expand into UvA's own prompting infrastructure (UvA Chat), since that platform doesn't support agentic deployment.

> Bas's "Socratic tutor" persona example (built on UvA Chat) was raised as a possible mention but the group agreed not to broaden scope this round.

> **Positioning:** The course is aimed at colleagues/PhDs for this first cohort, not students. The announcement will include explicit positioning language acknowledging that most current thesis/journal policies restrict GenAI use in written output — the course teaches awareness of the tools and their weak points, not blanket encouragement to use them everywhere.

3. Course Structure & Session Content

> **Finalized day/lab structure (per Marc's follow-up):** this supersedes the tentative pairings discussed live in the meeting below. Two new contributors join specific labs: **Ot** (possibly, on Lab 2) and **Yenan** (Lab 4) — neither was in the original planning meeting, so their involvement should be confirmed directly with Marc.

Intro (Day 1) — Leads: Gjorgji & Joaquim

- Walks participants through installing/setting up Claude Code and GitHub, and creating a GitHub account if needed (via team invite).
- Focus: organizing one's own research files well from the start (not GitHub's collaboration features like merge conflicts — that's a separate, harder topic). Present a simple, reusable project folder structure.
- Suggested to run as checkpointed live-along: explain a step, confirm everyone has caught up, then continue, so nobody falls behind on setup.
- Should briefly introduce the need for a "logbook"/reproducibility habit (see §5) without going deep — deeper tooling comes back in a later session once people have felt the pain of losing context.
- Gjorgji to build a PowerShell setup script for Windows users, so they can install prerequisites (Claude Code, GitHub) in one step rather than manually.

Lab 1 (Day 1): FD article — Leads: Marleen & her partner

- Take a scientific article and rewrite it as a journalistic piece (or podcast, or other public-facing format) using a custom `skill.md` that encodes house style, drawing on example articles for tone/reference.
- Marleen and her partner (who works at a financial-news outlet, "FD") will jointly run this lab and judge the success of turning a scientific paper into a news article — i.e., defining and applying the quality criteria a newsroom would use.
- Marleen to coordinate directly with her partner on scope and format, and report back to the group.

Lab 2 (Day 1, maybe Day 2): Privacy & Ethics — Leads: Gjorgji, Marc & Bas maybe also Ot

- Covers both angles of "ethics": what you can ask an LLM to do, and what people/sites allow LLMs to do.
- Hands-on contrast case: scrape the Rijksmuseum art collection (blocked via `robots.txt`) versus WikiArt (Creative Commons — scraping welcomed). Claude should visibly refuse one and succeed on the other, making the restriction tangible.

- Awareness of prompt injection: papers with hidden instructions telling automated reviewers to approve them; malicious instructions embedded in package READMEs that could exfiltrate credentials.
- Inventory of journal/publisher disclosure requirements for AI-assisted writing — have participants scrape/summarize the actual disclosure instructions from journal websites (largely public and easy for an LLM to find).
- Day placement (Day 1 vs. Day 2) still to be settled, depending on how the evening's timing works out alongside Lab 1.

Lab 3 (Day 2): Library tool — Leads: Gjorgji, Marc & Bas

- Exercise: vibe-code a personal tool that calls literature APIs (OpenAlex, Semantic Scholar, Scopus/SciVal) to support literature search. The learning objective is building a tool *that itself calls LLMs*, via natural-language coding — not hand-writing the search logic.
- Needs API keys: OpenAlex and Semantic Scholar are free/easy to obtain (often by return email); Scopus access is available via existing paid subscriptions (~€20/month tier already held by some of the group).
- Explicit caution to build into the material: don't let the tool replace reading — the goal is to surface better things to read, not to avoid reading. Participants should be warned about skill atrophy (losing the ability to read/write well) if they over-delegate.

Lab 4 (Day 3): Paper replication — Leads: Joaquim, Marleen & Yenan

- Participants replicate the computational/mathematical results of a real paper via "whitecoding," filling in methodological gaps the paper doesn't spell out.
- Candidate paper floated: one on political bias in LLMs (claims LLMs lean left). Not yet verified as actually replicable.
- Preference for papers built around a solid mathematical model (e.g., economics or business administration) — these are easier to replicate than papers that rely on narrative description alone.
- Bas has been doing similar informal replication work himself and reports frequently getting comparable results purely from a paper's narrative, via whitecoding — flagged as a possible design reference, though he felt fully "narrative + no source code" replication may be too narrow a case type for a mixed audience.

4. Roles & Responsibilities Summary

PERSON	PRIMARY RESPONSIBILITY THIS ROUND
Marc	Co-leads Lab 2 (Privacy & Ethics) with Gjorgji & Bas; co-leads Lab 3 (Library tool) with Gjorgji & Bas; thinks further about the overall course structure and session flow; co-leads the logistics workstream with Bas (room, schedule, equipment); drafts and circulates the course announcement, including the AI-policy positioning statement.
Gjorgji	Co-leads the intro session with Joaquim; co-leads Lab 2 (Privacy & Ethics) with Marc & Bas; co-leads Lab 3 (Library tool) with Marc & Bas; builds a PowerShell setup script for Windows users; shares his personal skills directory (including the `unslop` skill) as a reference resource for the group.
Marleen	Leads Lab 1 (FD article) together with her partner, judging the success of a scientific paper's translation into a news article; co-leads Lab 4 (Paper replication) with Joaquim & Yenan; coordinates directly with her partner on scope and reports back to the group.
Bas	Co-leads Lab 2 (Privacy & Ethics) with Gjorgji & Marc; co-leads Lab 3 (Library tool) with Gjorgji & Marc; co-leads the logistics workstream with Marc; raises cross-cutting questions (budget, UvA infrastructure scope, CPD credit).
Joaquim	Co-leads the intro session with Gjorgji; co-leads Lab 4 (Paper replication) with Marleen & Yenan; remains the administrative/logistics liaison — room and date availability, GitHub team/API-key arrangements, registration form platform, and CPD/credit-hour questions.
Ot **new, tentative**	Possibly joins Lab 2 (Privacy & Ethics) — to be confirmed with Marc.
Yenan **new**	Co-leads Lab 4 (Paper replication) with Joaquim & Marleen.

5. Recurring Themes to Weave Through the Course

- **Reproducibility / "logbook" habit:** Introduce the need for a memory/reproducibility habit in the intro, then circle back with a concrete example in a later lab once participants have felt the problem firsthand. Marleen described her own progression — plain text notes → Notion → Postgres → a dedicated agent-memory tool ("beads") — as a useful illustrative arc rather than something to prescribe on day one.
- **Skill files as portable instructions:** `skill.md` teaches a specific behavior/style to Claude for a given task; a general instruction file is better named `AGENTS.md` (not `CLAUDE.md`) so it also works with Codex and other tools. The group wants to maintain a shared pool of reusable skills over time.
- **Permission fatigue:** worth flagging that over-broad tool permissions are a real friction point — Marc now scopes permission prompts down to only file overwrite/delete, rather than approving every small action.

- **Awareness over encouragement:** repeatedly stated framing for the whole course — the goal is not to push maximal AI adoption, but to make people aware the tools exist, understand their failure modes, and use them without eroding their own critical reading/writing ability.

6. Open Questions / Not Yet Resolved

- Final dates and room booking — pending confirmation from the secretary (mostly Fridays and Wednesdays available in November per initial check).
- Whether attending the course can count toward participants' mandatory self-development/education credit hours, and whether facilitators can log hours for teaching it — Joaquim to check, unclear if it will be recognized at that level.
- Registration form platform — leaning Microsoft Forms rather than Qualtrics or Google Forms, to be confirmed with Joaquim's contact.
- Whether the library-tool exercise is scoped correctly, or is "too much engineering" for a course centered on vibe-coding with Claude Code (Gjorgji raised this concern; no final call made).
- Exact framing of Lab 2's second half (journal AI-disclosure policy scraping) — Gjorgji, Marc & Bas's joint task to work through; previously described as "homework."
- Whether Lab 2 (Privacy & Ethics) runs on Day 1 or Day 2 — not yet settled.
- Whether Ot is actually joining Lab 2, and how Yenan (joining Lab 4) fits into the wider group — both are new names not present at the original planning meeting; to confirm with Marc.

7. Follow-Up Action Items

1. **Gjorgji** & **Joaquim** — co-lead the intro session; Gjorgji to build a PowerShell setup script for Windows users and share his personal skills directory (including the `unslop` skill and example project structures) with the group as a working reference.
2. **Marleen** — coordinate with her partner on running Lab 1 (FD article) together, including how they'll judge the success of a scientific paper's translation into a news article; report back to the group once scoped.
3. **Gjorgji**, **Marc** & **Bas** — co-design Lab 2 (Privacy & Ethics) together, including the journal AI-disclosure policy inventory; settle whether Ot joins and whether it runs on Day 1 or Day 2.
4. **Gjorgji**, **Marc** & **Bas** — co-design Lab 3 (Library tool) together: firm up the learning objective (building a tool that itself calls LLMs) and scope the exercise.
5. **Joaquim**, **Marleen** & **Yenan** — co-design Lab 4 (Paper replication): sanity-check the candidate replication paper (political bias of LLMs) for actual replicability.
6. **Marc** — think further about the overall course structure (session flow and sequencing across the three days); draft the course announcement, including a one-to-two-sentence positioning statement on the course's stance toward existing university AI-use policies; share with the group before sending.
7. **Marc** & **Bas** — lead the logistics workstream together: confirm room availability, opening hours, and whether the floor power outlets actually work; lock in a Wednesday-evening slot outside 9–15 November.

8. **Joaquim** — check with the secretary on room/date availability; confirm the registration form platform; investigate GitHub team invitations and required API-key arrangements (OpenAlex, Semantic Scholar, Scopus) with the relevant contact; check on CPD/credit-hour recognition for participants and facilitators.
9. **All** — draft full outlines, examples, and a working exercise for each session; reconvene in **two weeks** with complete drafts for review.

Appendix A: Mind Map

Visual summary produced from the session recording.

